Chapter 4

Microscopic Weirdness

A

bit worn out from their trans-solar-system expedition, George and Gracie return to earth and head over to the H-Bar for some post-space-sojourning refreshments. George orders the usual—papaya juice on the rocks for himself and a vodka tonic for Gracie—and kicks back in his chair, hands clasped behind his head, to enjoy a freshly lit cigar. Just as he prepares to inhale, though, he is stunned to find that the cigar has vanished from between his teeth. Thinking that the cigar must somehow have slipped from his mouth, George sits forward expecting to find it burning a hole in his shirt or trousers. But it is not there. The cigar is not to be found. Gracie, roused by George's frantic movement, glances over and spots the cigar lying on the counter directly behind George's chair. "Strange," George says, "how in the heck could it have fallen over there? It's as if it went right through my head—but my tongue isn't burned and I don't seem to have any new holes." Gracie examines George and reluctantly confirms that his tongue and head appear to be perfectly normal. As the drinks have just arrived, George and Gracie shrug their shoulders and chalk up the fallen cigar to one of life's little mysteries. But the weirdness at the H-Bar continues.

George looks into his papaya juice and notices that the ice cubes are incessantly rattling around—bouncing off of each other and the sides of the glass like overcharged automobiles in a bumper-car arena. And this time he is not alone. Gracie holds up her glass, which is about half the size of George's, and both of them see that her ice cubes are bouncing around even more frantically. They can hardly make out the individual cubes as they all blur together into an icy mass. But none of this compares to what happens next. As George and Gracie stare at her rattling drink with wide-eyed wonderment, they see a single ice cube pass through the side of her glass and drop down to the bar. They grab the glass and see that it is fully intact; somehow the ice cube went right through the solid glass without causing any damage. "Must be post-space-walk hallucinations," says George. They each fight off the frenzy of careening ice cubes to down their drinks in one go, and head home to recover. Little do George and Gracie realize that in their haste